

borrowed and re-borrowed, and, therefore, cannot be really used as evidence for establishing genetic affiliation. Instead, I will concentrate here on few words from the Xiong-nu language that belong to basic vocabulary (some of them only to a certain extent).

a) *kwala "son" (孤塗). Pulleyblank compares this word with Arin *bīkjāl* "son" (with *bi-* as a prefix), but Arin word seems to be isolated in Yeniseian: other Yeniseian languages have words based on Proto-Yeniseian (PY) *puʔ-b "son" (Starostin 1995: 252): Ket *hiʔp*, Yug *fiʔp*, Kott *fup*, Assan *pup*. It seems that there are no alternative Altaic etymologies for Xiong-nu *kwala "child." Old Japanese *kwo* "child" superficially seems plausible (*kwo* < *ku[C]a or *ka[C]u), but it is likely to be related to Tungusic *kuŋa- "child", and, therefore, is not applicable here.

b) *kuti "horse" (馱驥). Appears to be a good match: PY *kuʔs "horse" > Ket *kuʔs*, Yug *kuʔs*, Kott *huš*, Arin *kus/qus*, Pumpokol *kut* (Starostin 1995: 240). One minor problem is that the Xiong-nu form has *-t-* like Pumpokol, but unlike other Yeniseian languages. The other problem is however, more serious: the word for "horse", although it does belong to basic vocabulary, can be borrowed (cf. Old Japanese *uma/muma* "horse" < Old Chinese *mra "id.").

c) *ket, ethnonim Jie = "stone?" (羯). Pulleyblank compares it with Arin *kes* and Pumpokol *kit* "stone". However, nowadays we know that both forms are results of fortitions typical for these languages, and that they go back to PY *čiʔs "stone", along with Ket *tīʔs*, Yug *čiʔs*, Kott *šiš*, Assan *šiš*, Koibal *šiš* (Starostin 1995: 217–218). Pulleyblank believed that there are two Yeniseian etymons for "stone", one with initial *k-* and another with initial *c-* (1962: 246), but he was misled by the fact that there are two Pumpokol forms for stone, *kit*, and *cis*. The latter is actually a Yug form, mislabeled "Pumpokol" (Helimskii 1985). This fact was not known in 1960s, and Pulleyblank, of course, could not avoid this mistake. We are left with two distinct possibilities here: (1) to speculate that Xiong-nu had the same fortitions as Pumpokol, which is not impossible (cf. the word for "horse" above), (2), to treat the term not as a "stone", but as an ethnonim. In this case it does resemble closely the PY term *keʔt "person", "human being" > Ket *keʔt*, Yug *keʔt*, Kott *hit/hett*, Assan *hit*, Arin *kit/qit*, Pumpokol *kit* (Starostin 1995: 236).